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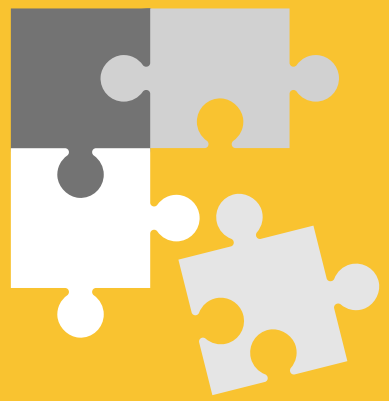
SARA KIEL | SYNCHRONY BUSINESS SOLUTIONS

SBS ANALYTICS USER EXPERIENCE AUDIT & RECOMMENDATIONS



JUNE 2025

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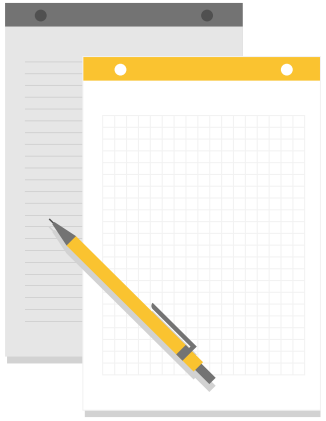
AGENDA

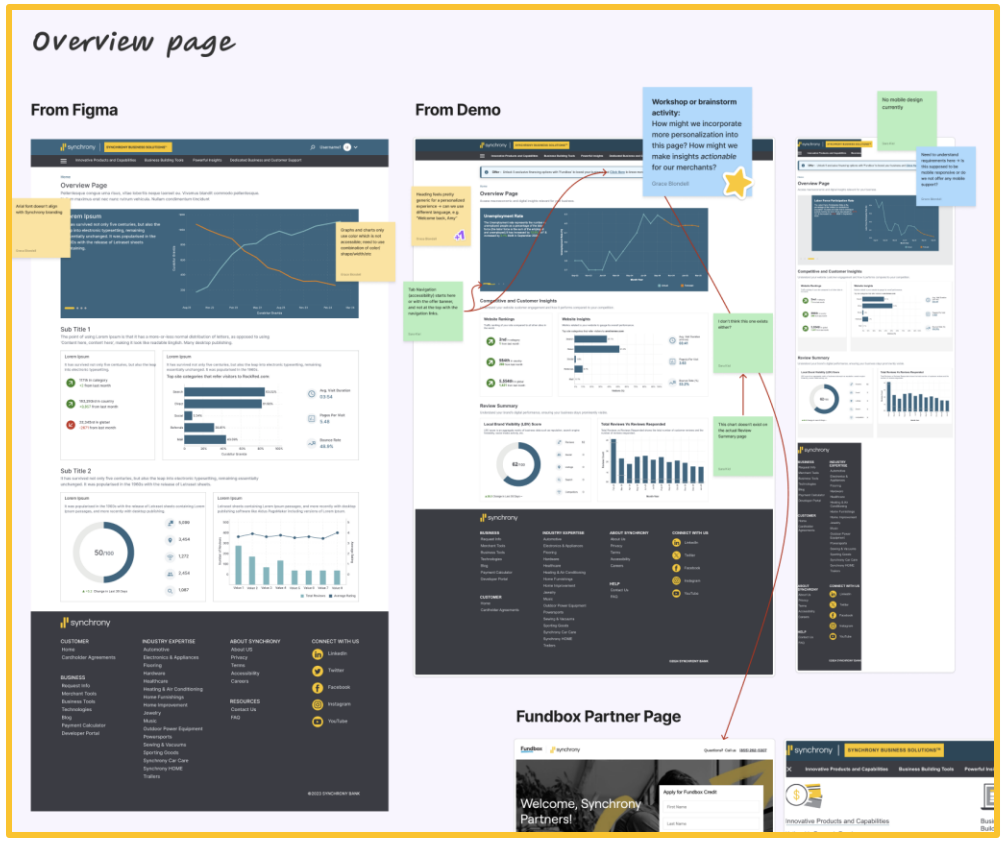


- Overview
- Themes & Opportunities
- Next Steps
- Design Ops
- Appendix

OVERVIEW

Audit Process

- High-level review of SBS Analytics based on UX best practices, data visualization best practices, usability heuristics, and accessibility guidelines
- Content mapping for better understanding of the relationship between pages and content
- Reviewed "competitor" websites
- Affinity mapping to identify themes amongst noted observations and feedback
- Refined themes into 3 overarching opportunity areas to be considered during a future redesign

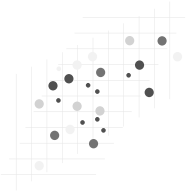


Executive Summary

There are several opportunities to improve SBS Analytics's clarity, consistency, and overall user experience. Inconsistent visual design, fragmented navigation, and inefficient data visualizations contribute to cognitive overload and impact user engagement.

By establishing a unified design system and improving layout and interaction patterns, SBS can create a more intuitive and accessible product. Additionally, enhancing data storytelling through simplified visualizations, personalized insights, and clearer content connections will help users more easily interpret their data and take meaningful action.

These improvements can align the product more closely with user expectations and industry best practices.



Adjusting visualizations to best fit data visualization best practices

Ensuring that content is consistent, clear, and valuable to the user

Leaning more into the dashboard design and navigation style

Addressing accessibility in all of the above

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THEMES & OPPORTUNITIES

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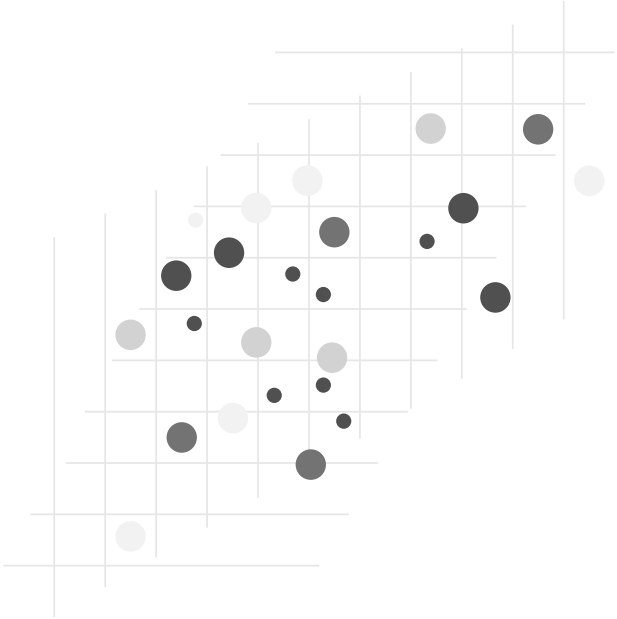
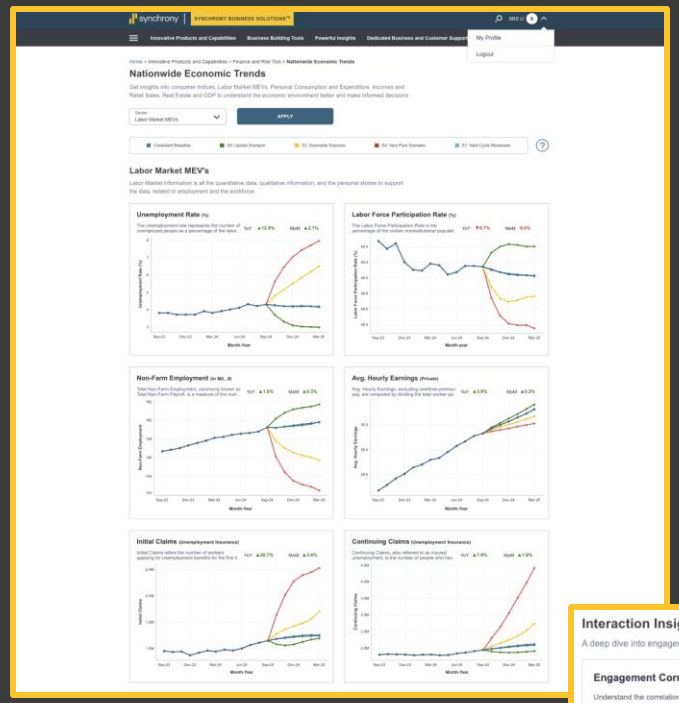
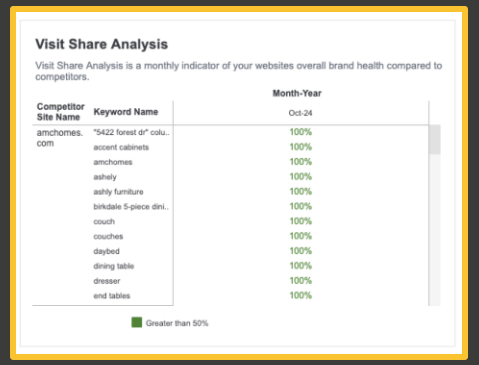
Adjusting visualizations to best fit data visualization best practices

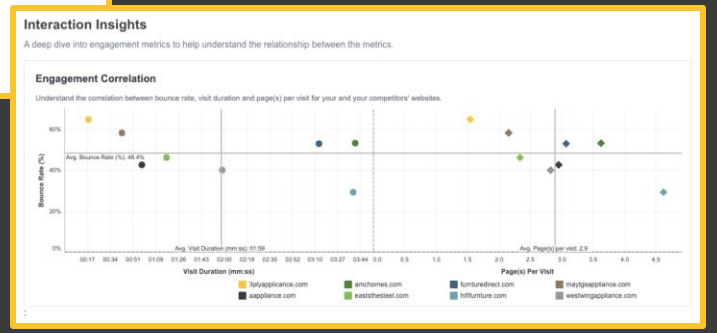


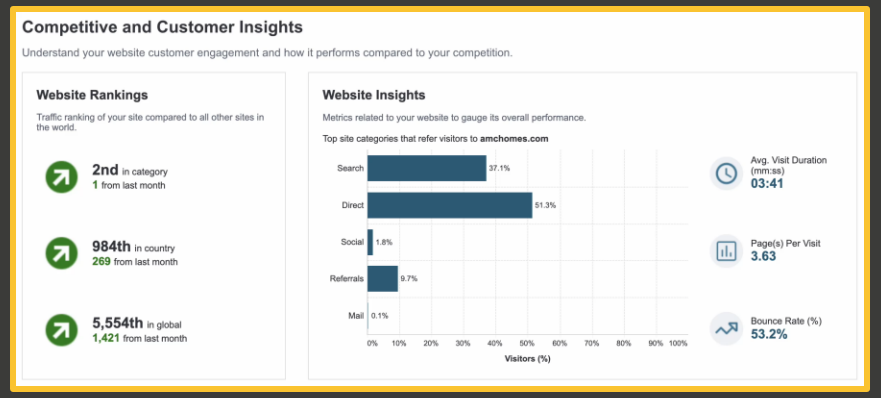
Key Observations

- Charts are displayed at a small scale relative to the whole page, making it difficult to interpret data
- The effectiveness of certain visualizations is questionable, with some not being easily digestible due to large amounts of data
- There are chart elements that are not necessary and could be removed/edited for simplicity
- Many graph filters and view switches are confusing and their use not always intuitive
- LOTS of fake clickable/hover content throughout the platform, yet some elements actually do have a click/hover interaction









Opportunity Area

Adjusting visualizations to best fit data visualization best practices will help users more easily extract actionable insights from their data.

Removing/editing unnecessary chart elements will reduce user cognitive load and simplify the overall design.

- Remove chart elements that don't contribute to a user's understanding of the data
- Resize charts to better fit available space and prioritize legibility
- Remove unused hover/click interactions

Reconsidering the design of potentially ineffective visualizations will contribute to better data storytelling and provide more context to the user.

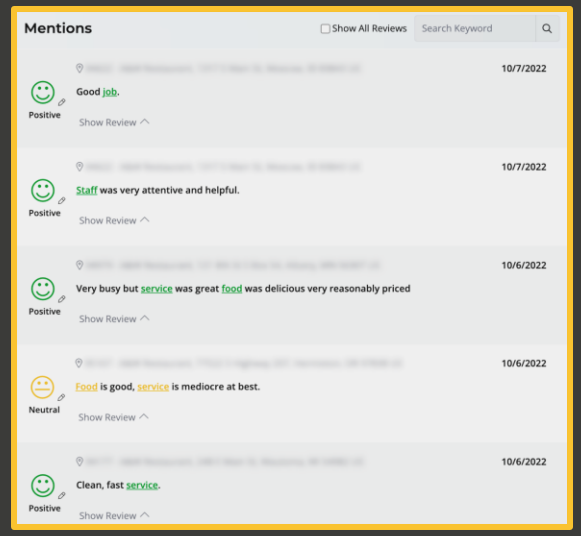
- Replace cluttered or dense visualizations with simpler formats
- Consider aforementioned personalization opportunities (emphasizing trends, key takeaways)
- Consider additional summaries/callouts to visualize insights beyond the use of just charts/graphs

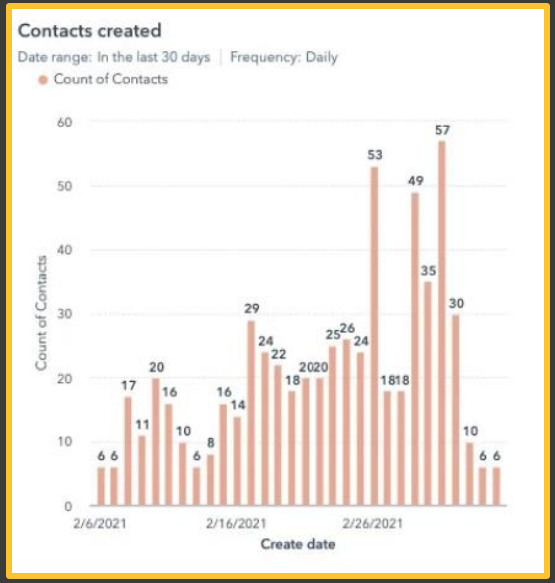
Ensuring that content is consistent and valuable to the user helps improve comprehension and support a more intuitive and personalized experience.

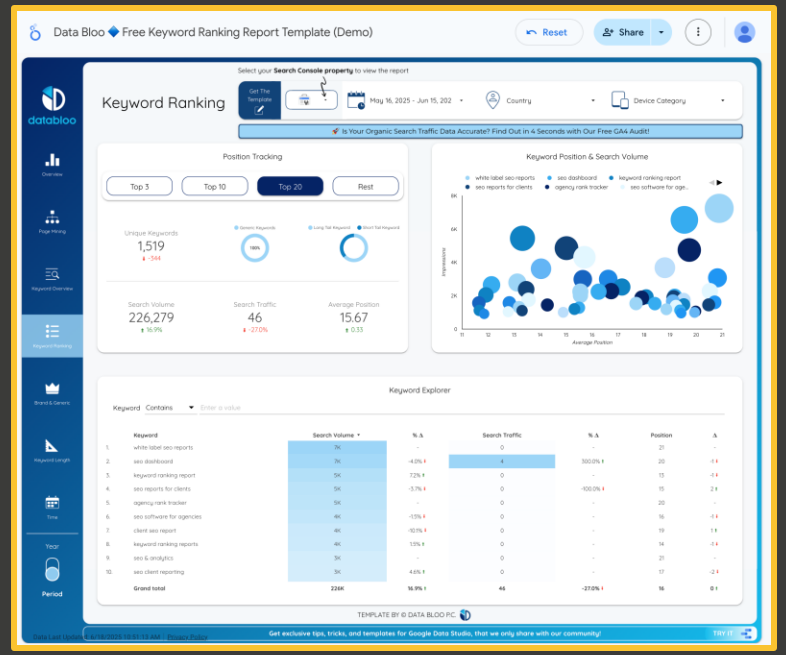
- Clarify confusing filters or toggle controls to improve usability
- Standardize interaction cues (hovers/clicks) so they align with the user expectations
- Align all visual elements with the same logic and layout across pages

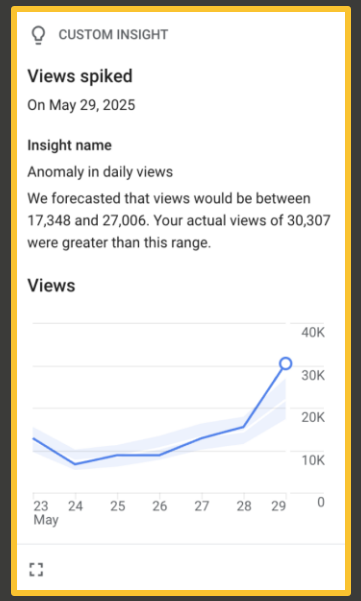
Competitor Examples

- A recent reviews design created by Chatmeter that utilizes color and iconography
- A bar graph by Hubspot that uses fewer visual elements (vertical graph lines in this instance)
- A full keyword dashboard by Data Bloo with clearer formatting of long lists of keywords
- A line graph from Google Analytics that uses fewer visual elements and provides insights into what the user is seeing









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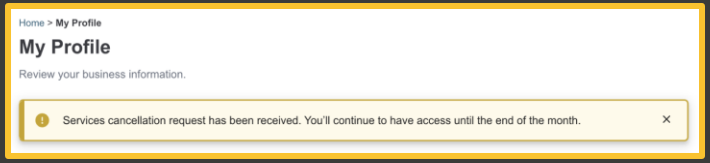
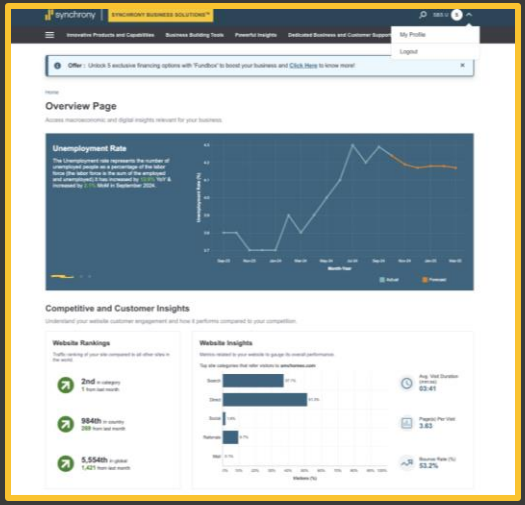
Ensuring that content is consistent, clear, and valuable to the user

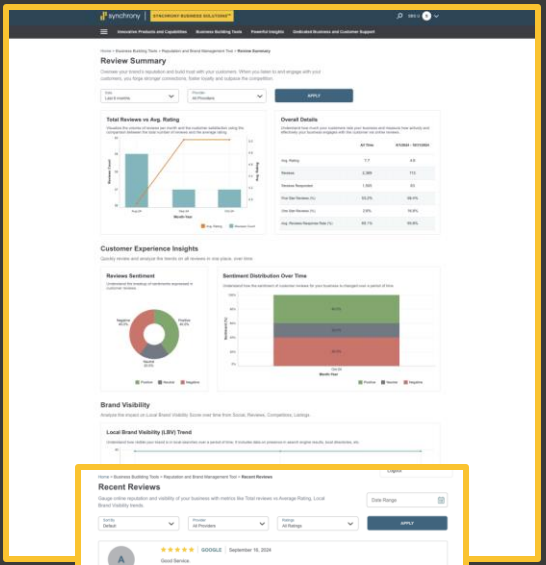
Key Observations

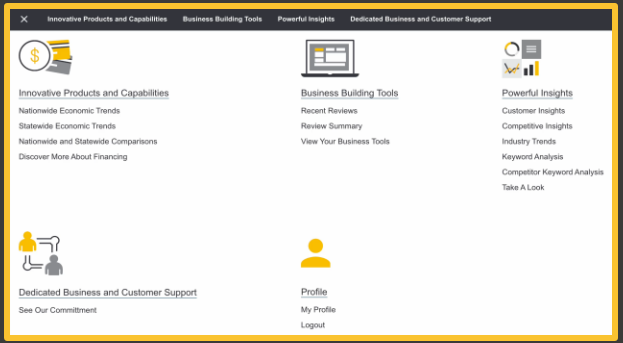
- There are misspelled words present in the copy*
- There is copy present that could be edited for better sentence structure, clarity, and conciseness
- We are currently assuming that users are familiar with all abbreviations present (MEVs, GDP, PCE, etc.)*
- The Overview Page is fairly generic and lacks personalization
- Lots of raw data present but a lack of actionable insights, recommendations, and how-to-use instructions
- Connected and similar pages (e.g., "Recent Reviews" and "Review Summary") don't maintain a consistent display of information
- There is a lot of inconsistency and ambiguity in navigation links/menus

*These observations were noted for the demo environment, but may not be present in production









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Opportunity Area

Ensuring that content is consistent, clear, and valuable to the user helps improve comprehension and support a more intuitive and personalized experience.

More proofreading/copywrite processes are needed to avoid errors and reduce confusion.

- Fix types and grammatical errors that may impact trust and credibility
  - Demo-specific
- Simplify sentence structure and edit for clarity in areas like tooltips, supporting text, etc.
- Review abbreviation use and avoid assuming user familiarity

There is an opportunity for more personalization and/or the incorporation of AI for recommendations, insights, etc.

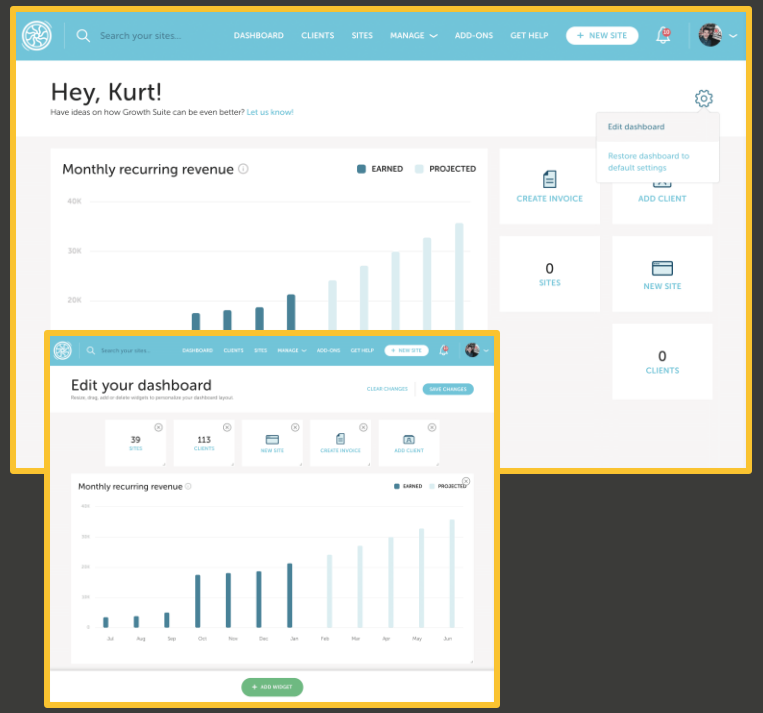
- Customize overview page with user-specific summaries/trends
- Incorporate automated suggestions or contextual help, such as, "What this [trend] means for you."
- Leverage user behavior to guide recommendations or default chart views
- Add the option for the user to edit the layout of their overview page, especially if opting for a more dashboard style (next theme!)

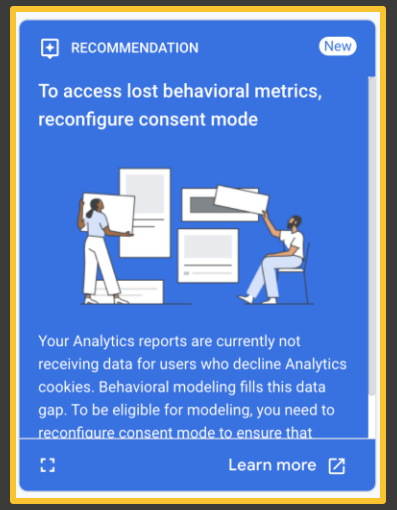
Improving consistency and connection between related content will make information easier to digest and enhance the overall UX.

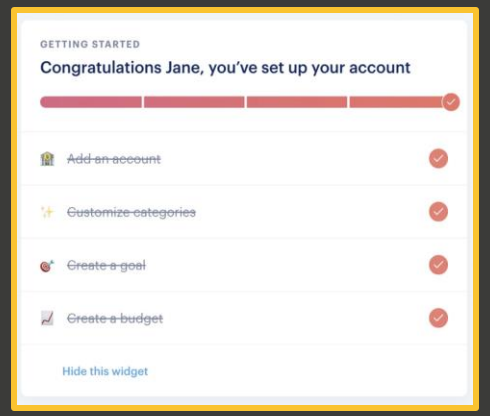
- Fix the disconnect between the navigation links and the hamburger menu (more on this in the next theme)
- Ensure similar pages use the same layout structure, terminology, and labeling
- Cross-link/cross-reference related information when necessary
  - Recent Reviews should appear on the Review Summary page

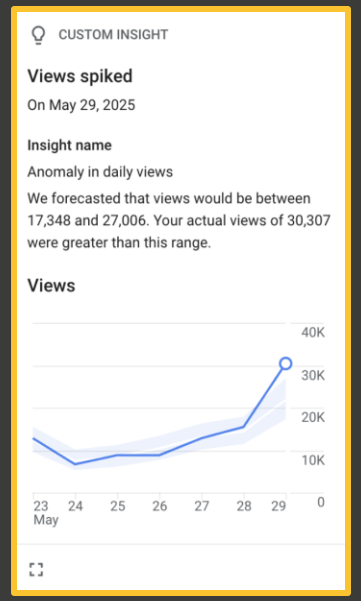
Competitor Examples

- A standard dashboard design from Flywheel, utilizing a bento box layout with a personalized greeting and the option to edit the dashboard layout
- Two cards from Google Analytics, both with personalized recommendations/insights based on data
- A "Getting Started" card from Monarch, with recommendations on next steps for a new user









Leaning more into the dashboard design and navigation style

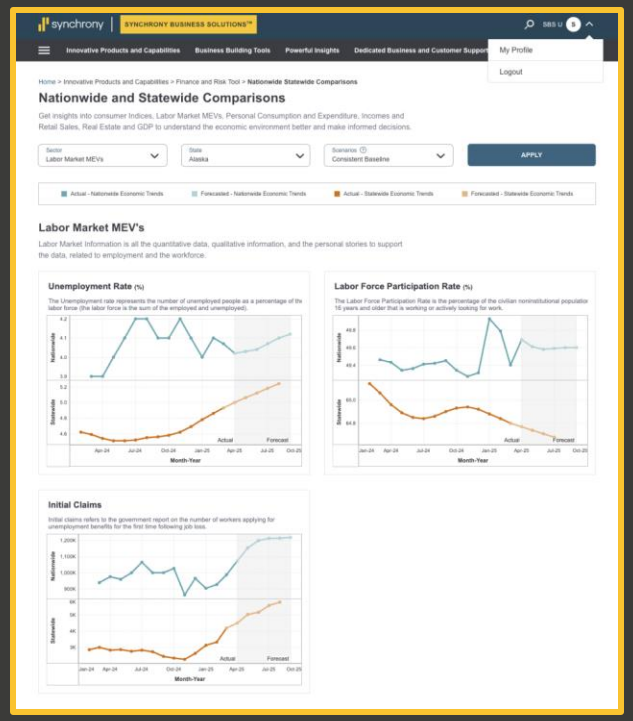
Key Observations

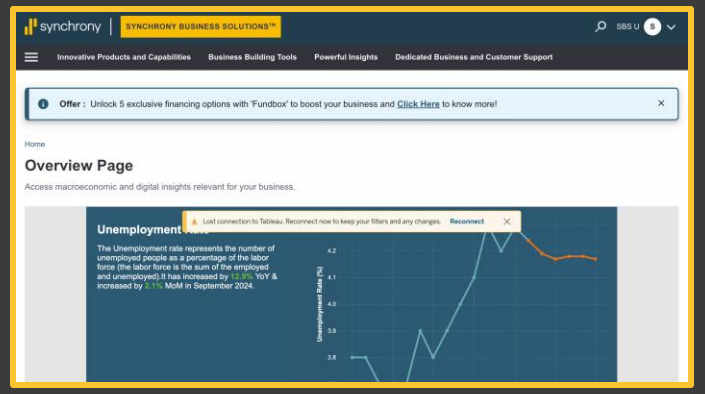
From Competitive Analysis: Digital Products frequently take on more of a dashboard look

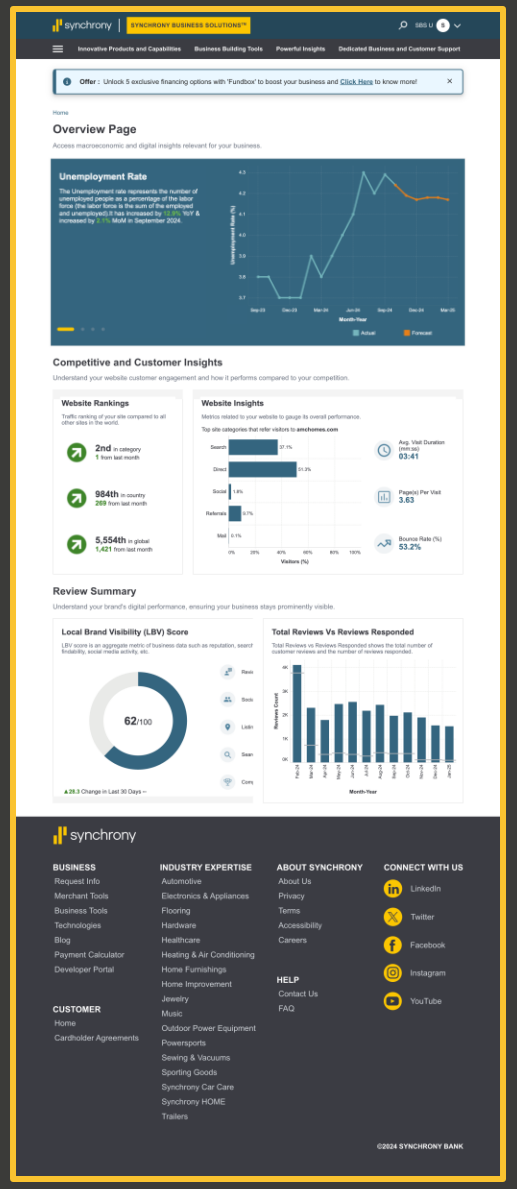
- Left-hand/local navigation present
- Cards, background color, and bento box layouts create separation between data

SBS Analytics:

- There are no consistent rules around spacing
- There is potentially too much white space on each page, consequently causing graphs to be smaller in scale
- Navigation breadcrumbs aren't clickable
- Navigation between pages and sections is currently difficult
- Not all web pages are represented in the page footer
- The "hamburger menu" takes up the entire screen when open, disrupting navigation





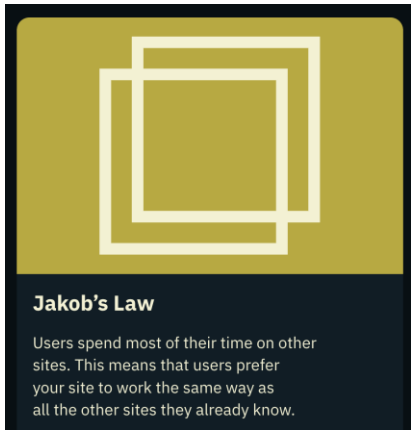


Opportunity Area

Leaning more into the dashboard design and navigation style helps modernize the product, improves content discoverability, and better aligns with user expectations.

An intuitive and familiar layout would streamline the UX and improve the perceived professionalism of SBS Analytics.

- Adopt common dashboard conventions such as left-hand navigation and modular card layouts
- Use background colors or visual boundaries to separate content areas and improve page scannability
- Create rules around spacing to bring consistency across pages



Optimizing navigation patterns will reduce user friction and support continued platform exploration.

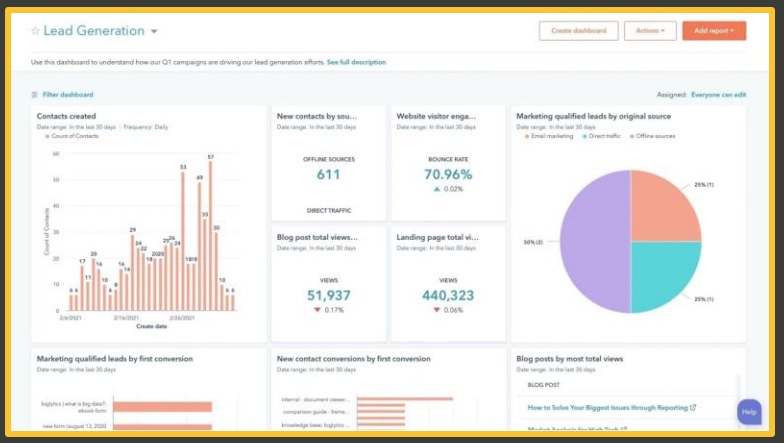
- Make breadcrumbs clickable to help users orient themselves
- Redesign the footer:
  - Include all key pages in the footer for easier access; OR
  - Reformat the footer to match a product-style rather than marketing-style
- Fix the disconnect between the navigation links and the hamburger menu:
  - Hamburger menu can potentially be removed and only used for mobile design (if applicable)
  - Value-added services/resources could fall under their own dedicated section
  - Adjust page titles/sections for consistency and clarity

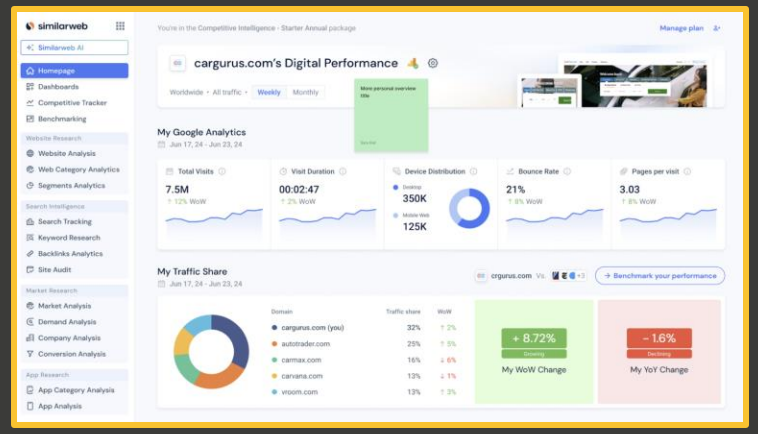
Redesigning visual clutter and white space can improve content focus and elevate data visualization clarity.

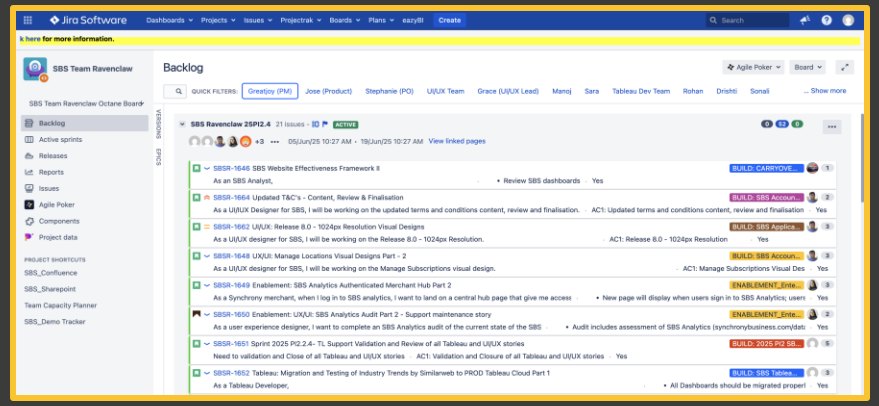
- Optimize white space to balance page and content density
- Ensure graphs scale appropriately and are not minimized due to layout choices
- Reconsider hamburger menu's full-page overlay, which currently interrupts the user flow

Competitor Examples

- Three different dashboard designs with similar layouts from:
  - Hubspot
  - Similarweb
  - Jira
- All incorporate cards and background colors to differentiate between data and content groups
- Similarweb & Jira have local/left-hand navigation
- Key visualizations in the Hubspot dashboard are sized larger, allowing for easier viewing







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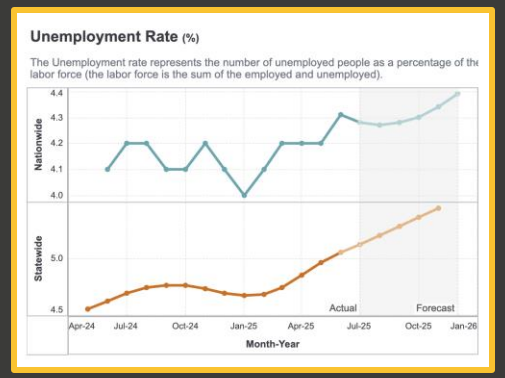
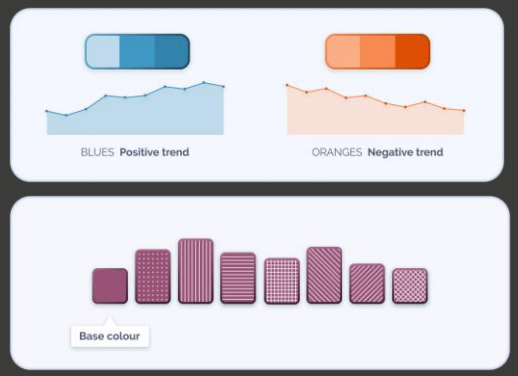
Addressing accessibility in all of the above

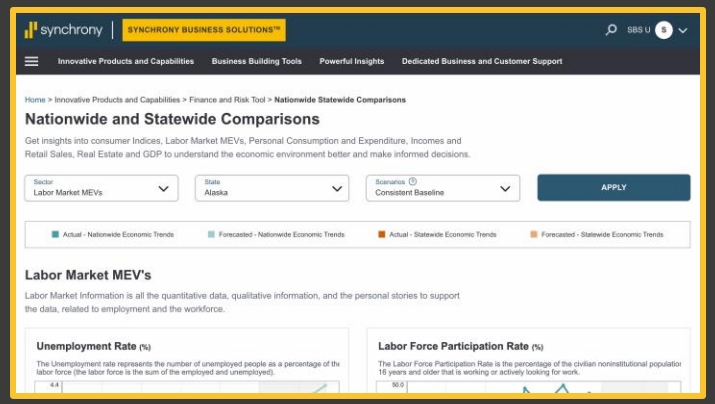
Addressing Accessibility

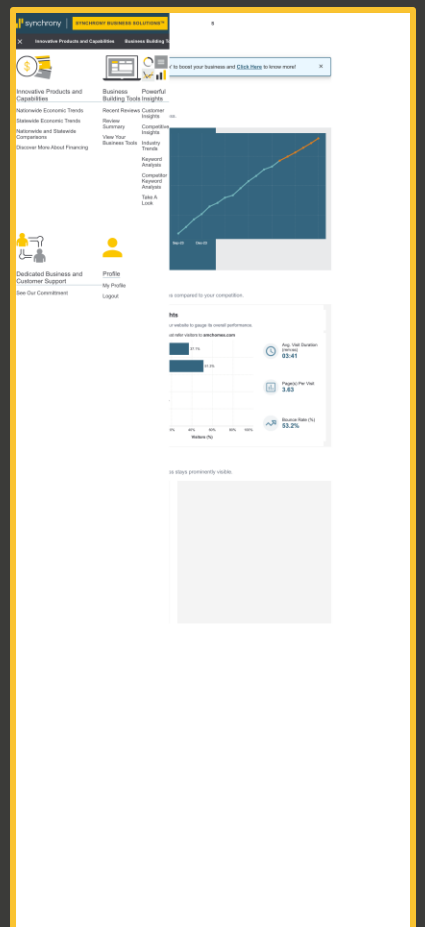
- Visualizations do not currently follow accessibility guidelines
- The website doesn't currently handle resized windows very well*
- Not all important page elements are currently accessible with keyboard navigation:
  - Scenarios & Assumptions (Moody's pages)
  - Navigation Links
- No mobile design currently – is this something we want in the future?

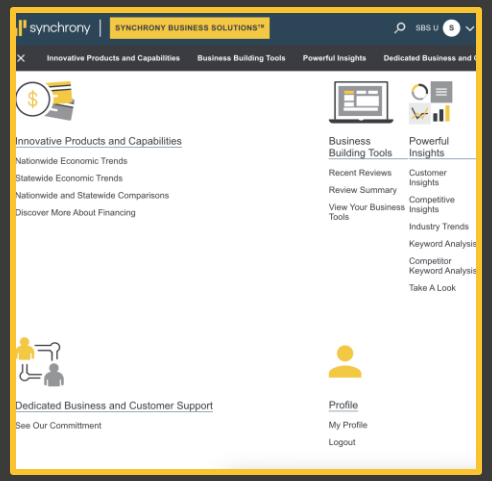




pencilandpaper.io







*This observation was noted for the demo environment, but may not be present in production

NEXT STEPS

Next Steps

Establish a unified design system to ensure consistency, clarity, and accessibility.

- Develop a component library with standardized styles
- Create layout templates for key pages
- Apply accessibility guidelines to all elements
- Define interaction rules (hovers, clicks)
- Revise copy for clarity, tone, and terminology (abbreviations)

Improve navigation and data storytelling to enhance user experience and engagement.

- Redesign key navigational structures
  - Breadcrumbs
  - Footer
  - Hamburger menu
- Align chart types and layouts with storytelling goals in mind
- Support personalization and contextualization
  - Opportunity to incorporate AI
- Clarify filter and toggle mechanisms
- Ensure all related content is logically connected

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DESIGN OPS

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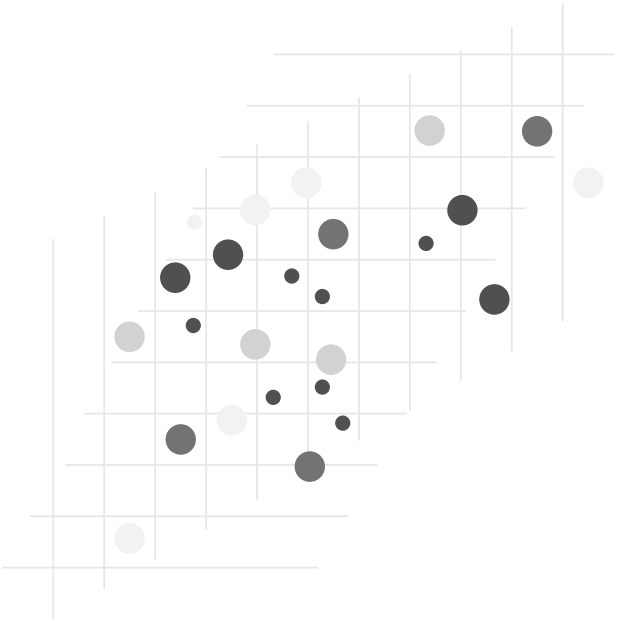
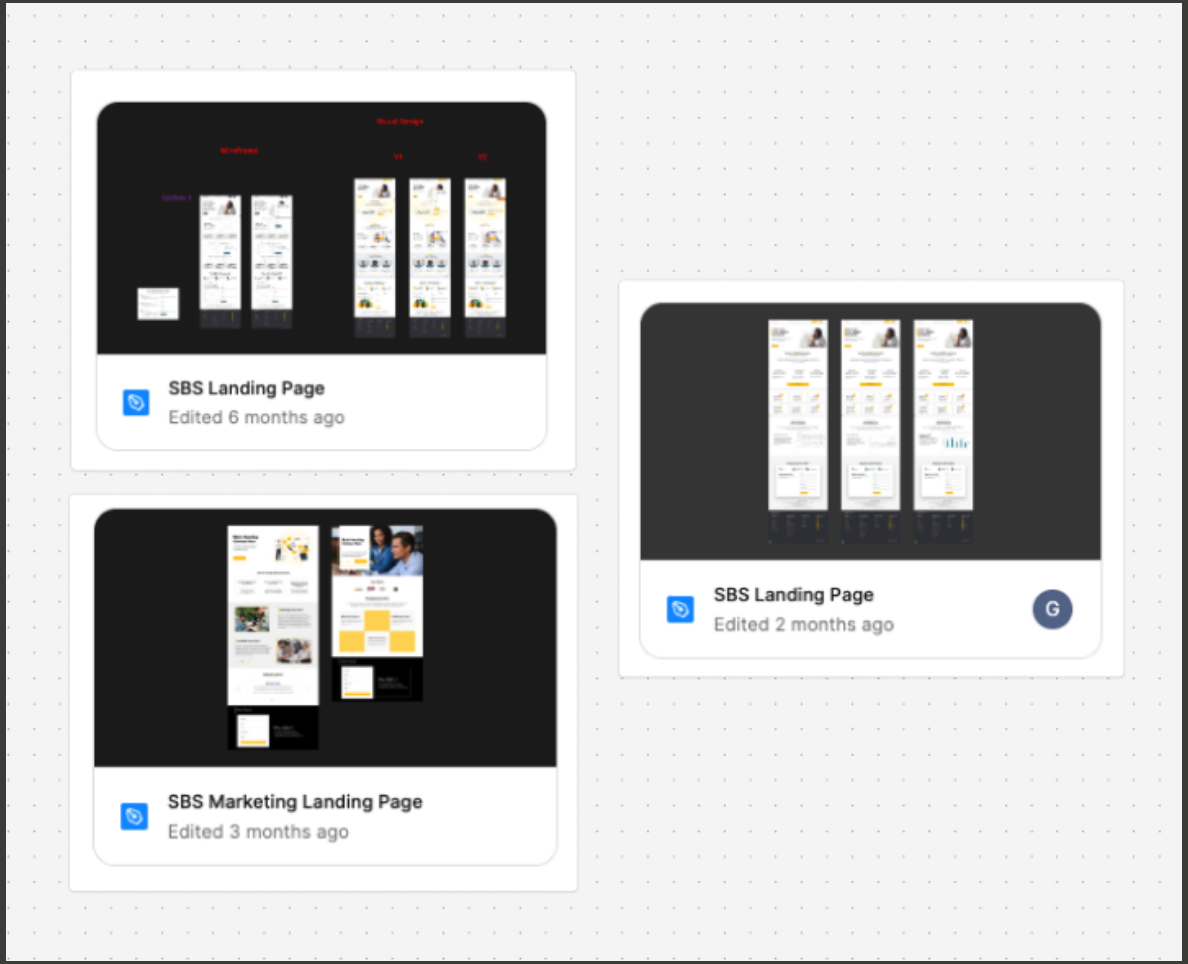
Optimizing Figma for efficiency and scalability will enable us to deliver work faster, with fewer errors



Key Observations

- **Lack of single source of truth**
  - Multiple sources of truth creates additional work for designers who need to maintain multiple files while also making it difficult for team members to understand what should be their primary reference
  - Lacking a demo URL or Figma prototype that accurately represents what is currently in production
- **Inefficient, non-scalable designs**
  - Designs that don't use components or auto-layout are cumbersome to make edits in
  - We don’t have access to "real" design files for pages owned by Synchrony Business – just screenshots – so it's difficult to make updates
- **Confusing Figma organization**
  - Several files have the same name
  - Within files, it's hard to understand which page has the "final" version of designs



Recommendations

- **Figma Restructuring – IN PROGRESS**
  - Each Project in Figma will represent a product, e.g. SBS Analytics, Emails, Merchant Hub, SynchronyBusiness.com, etc.
- **Figma Cleanup – NOT STARTED**
  - Consolidate duplicate/similar files
  - Merge all Moody's designs into 1 file; same for Chatmeter and Similarweb
  - Add cover thumbnails to files
  - Within files, update page names to provide clarity on design status
- **Design System Buildout – NOT STARTED**
  - Build out components and set up styles
- **Release File Changes – NOT STARTED**
  - Move away from copying designs into the release file and instead include release notes with links that reference the original design files

APPENDIX

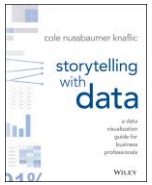
Audit Rubric

Google Lighthouse

Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics

Laws of UX

W3C WCAG (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines) 2.2



Storytelling with Data
Book by Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic

Figure 1. Current Site Navigation

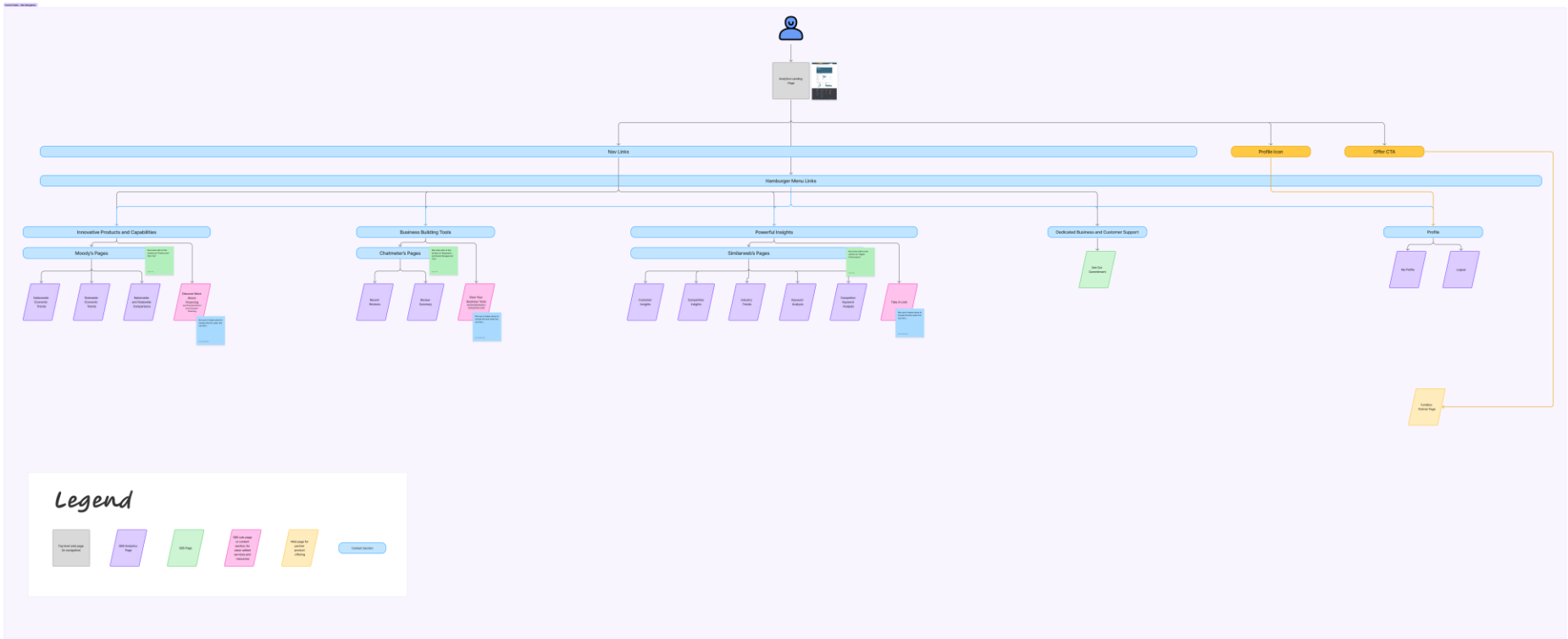


Figure 2. and Figure 3. Themes & Recommendations Mapping

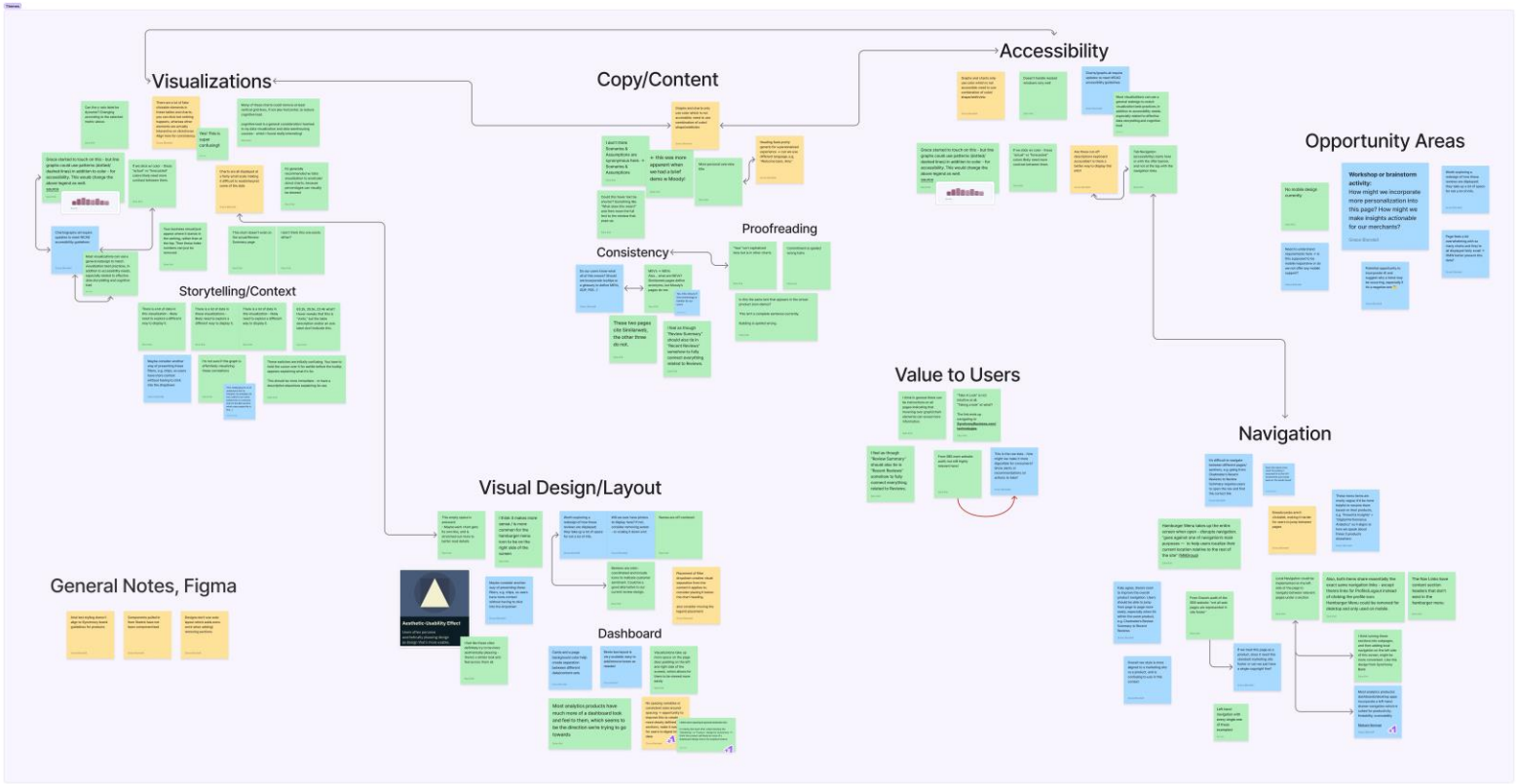


Figure 2.

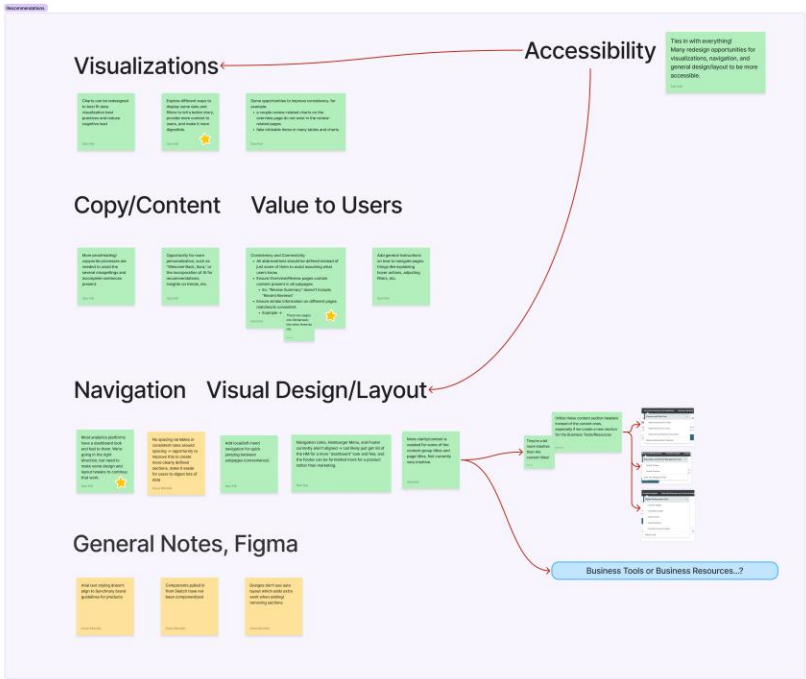
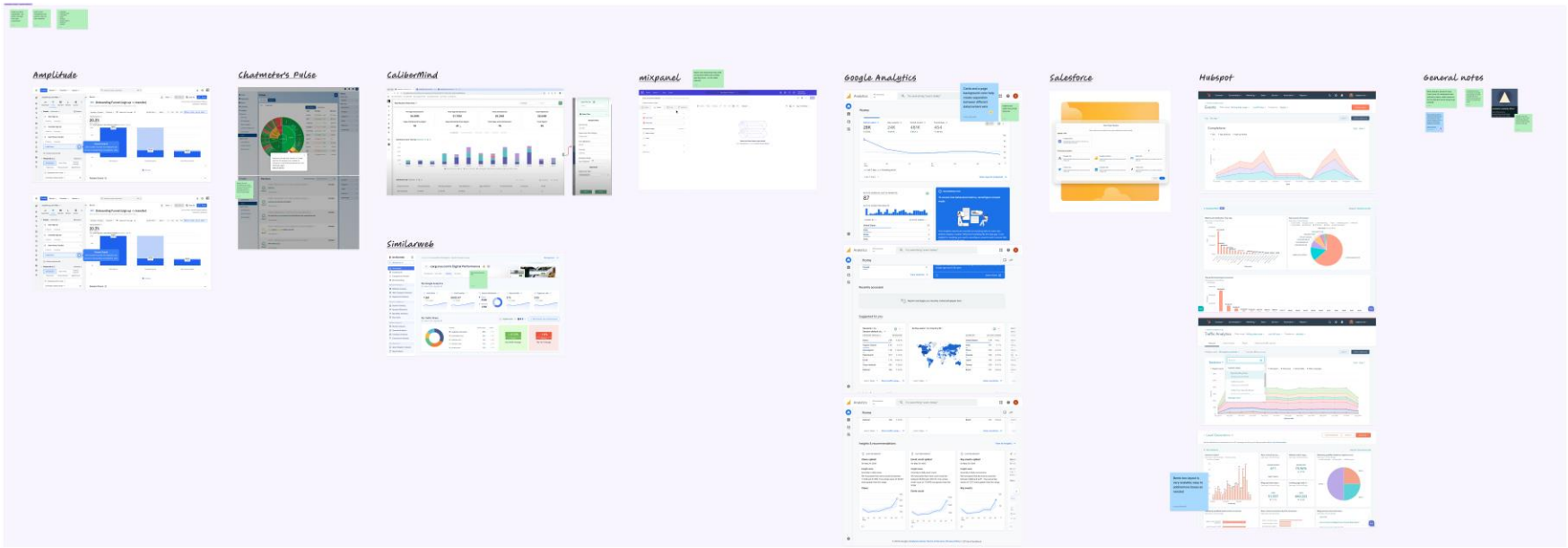
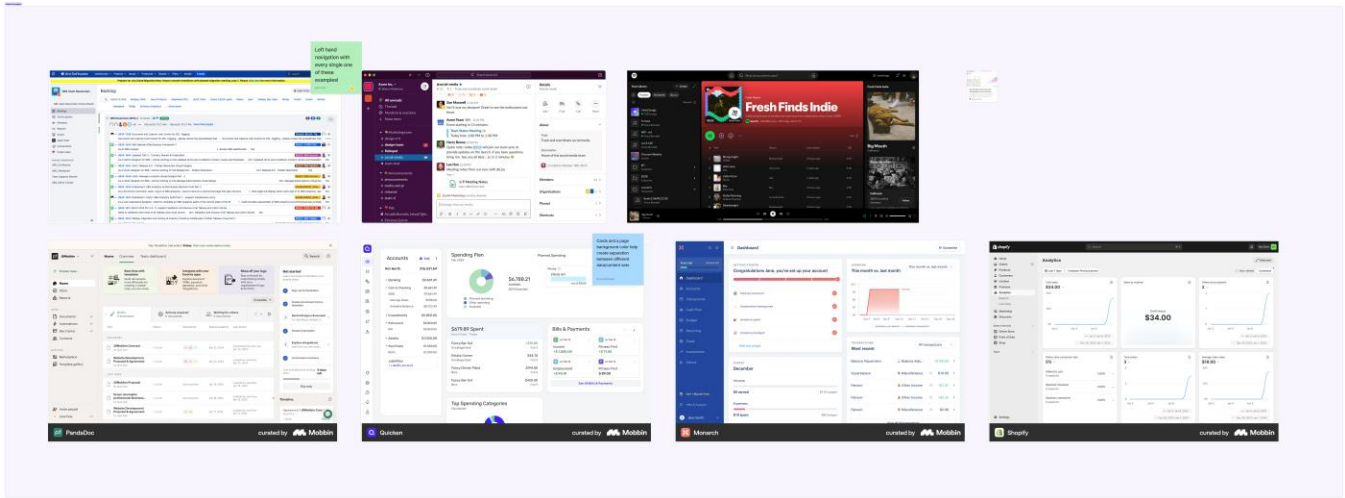


Figure 3.

Figure 4. Competitive Analysis





synchrony